



**FALLING APART:** Mobs rule the streets in the state

deceptive calm follows, and it lasts just two days. Then begins the campaign, quite incendiary in nature, and it goes like this: the Hindus are coming, it's cultural invasion, it's demographic sabotage, the land will be used for permanent settlement... The state Government, on its part, fails to convince the Valley that there is no transfer of ownership—a fatal communication gap.

The separatists—or secessionists?—have been waiting for a provocation. They get one and nobody bothers to read the fine print. Such anti-India veterans and wholesale merchants of hate as Syed Ali Shah Geelani and Mirwaiz Umar Farooq hit the streets and declare war on the country which still indulges them. National Conference President Omar Abdullah and PDP chief Mehbooba Mufti, driven by the fear of losing their political space in the Valley to the Hurriyat, join the anti-national movement and demand the revocation of the order. Mehbooba threatens withdrawal of support to the Government if the order is not revoked by June 30. Azad succumbs. Sinha has been replaced by N.N. Vohra, a former home secretary and a favourite of the prime minister. The Congress high command—read 10 Janpath—decides to repeat what it is traditionally good at: minority appeasement. And it has a trust vote to win in Parliament and every vote counts,

including Mehbooba's and Omar's. Governor Vohra becomes a servile instrument of his political employer and the order is revoked.

Nothing more has been required for the emotional as well as cultural Balkanisation of the state. The economic blockade initiated by the protagonists of the Amarnath cause has only helped the mobilisation of anti-India—which means pro-Pakistan—sentiment in the Valley. No nationalist—not to speak of the Government—has come forward to the rescue of India. The most visible flag in Srinagar has the Islamic crescent on it. Suddenly, Mirwaiz, Geelani, Yasin Malik and Omar are united in their cause. When they mention “New Delhi”, it sounds like an imperial foreign capital. It's the cry of *azadi* all over again. The secessionists, whom “New Delhi” lets flourish in the Valley, now demand the release of all political prisoners and demilitarisation of the state.

Kashmir is falling apart, and it seems the Centre cannot hold. Or short-term political expediency has triumphed over long-term national interest. The tragedy of the Valley cannot be reduced to the size of that anodyne comedy called Shivraj Patil. Then he also happens to be the home minister of India, and going by what he says—which is as revealing as Bushisms—and does, we still don't know what his idea of internal security is. He should be doing something more tolerable. And for the National Security Adviser, Kashmir is not a favourite destination. Even the nationalism of the nationalists has a political subtext. BJP leader L.K. Advani may be right when he says that “the problem in Jammu and Kashmir today is not Hindu versus Muslim; nor is it even Jammu region versus the Valley. It is essentially nationalists versus the separatists.” The Saffronites, by championing the cause of the shrine board, have turned the crisis into a real estate dispute between the aggrieved Hindu and the appeased Muslim.

The reality is much more frightening: the real estate at stake is bigger than those 40 hectares. The territorial ambition of the secessionists—what else does *azadi* mean?—has made Kashmir a disputed land, at least for a section of its inhabitants. A Government that governs by communal appeasement and a political class that betrays the nation for the expansion of the votebank have only added to the force of hate. It's a war within, and those who have the mandate to keep the unity of India intact are supplying the ammunition. The villains of the Valley are the enemies of the Republic as well. ■

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